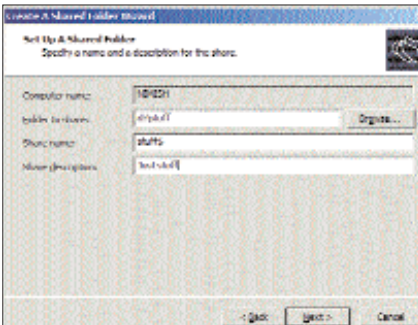


into their properties and changing them one by one can be quite a nuisance. Even sharing can be as simple as “Next, next, and next” with the Shared Folder Wizard (Start > Run > “shrpwb” > [Enter]).

You can even set share permissions right there, so there’s no need to go back to those shared folders for additional settings. Just remember to check the “Run this wizard again” box at the last dialog if you want to move on to the next folder.



Use the Sharing Wizard to share many folders

Speed Up With A USB Stick

If you’ve got yourself a large USB Flash drive (at least 1 GB, preferably 2), you can move your system’s page file onto it for significantly better performance, because accessing flash memory is typically faster than your average hard disk.

You should also optimise the Flash drive for performance—right-click on it in My Computer, select Properties. Go to the Hardware tab, select your Flash drive and click Properties. Under the Policies tab, select “Optimise for performance”.

A couple of caveats: Firstly, if you remove this drive while Windows is running, you could cause it to crash, so be careful there. Secondly, Flash drives are good only for limited read/write cycles, so this approach is definitely going to eat into its lifetime. Use this tip only for when you really need the performance boost rather than as a permanent solution.

Bad Doggie!

The Microsoft obsession with annoying animated characters didn’t end with the demise of Clippy—here’s how you can get rid of the animated dog that turns up every time you want to search for files.

In the search window, click Change Preferences > Without an animated screen character.

Furthermore, to get back the Windows 2000-style search window, go to Change Preferences > Change files and folders search behaviour and select Advanced. Finally—sensible search.

Tune ClearType

With XP, Microsoft introduced ClearType, which improves the quality of fonts displayed on your screen, especially if you’re using an LCD monitor. However, the results on CRT monitors were a tad disappointing. However, with a little fine-tuning, you can get satisfactory results too. Just visit www.microsoft.com/typography/cleartype/tuner/Step1.aspx using Internet Explorer to start up the ClearType Tuner. The site will ask you if you want to download the ActiveX control. Accept it and go through the necessary steps to get the best ClearType setting for you. Alternatively, you could get the ClearType Tuner powetoy here: www.microsoft.com/typography/ClearTypePowerToy.msp

Trash Files With Crowded Desktops

If you want to drag a file to the Recycle Bin, but have too many windows open, just drag the file to an empty area on the taskbar—the windows will all minimise, giving you free and uninterrupted access to the Recycle bin!

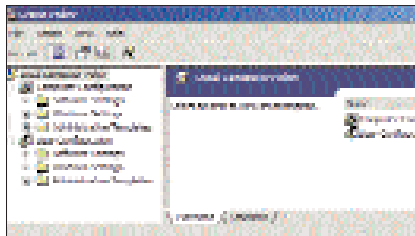
Start > Run Shortcuts

Use these shortcuts in Start > Run to get to your configuration tools faster in Windows XP Professional:

compmgmt.msc	Computer management console
devmgmt.msc	Device manager
diskmgmt.msc	Disk management
dfrg.msc	Disk defragmenter
fsmgmt.msc	Shared folders
gpedit.msc	Group policy editor
lusrmgr.msc	Local users and groups
perfmon.msc	Performance monitor
secpol.msc	Local security settings
services.msc	Manage services

AVOID THE REGISTRY

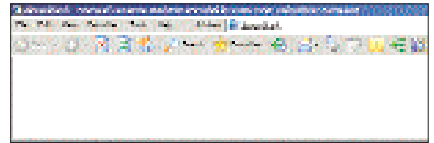
You don’t really need the Registry Editor or third-party tools for every single tweak you want to make to Windows. If you’re using XP Professional (sorry, Home Edition users), the Group Policy Editor (Start > Run > gpedit.msc > [Enter]) hides an obscene number of settings that you can use to control your PC. If you’re a domain administrator, these settings affect all users under your domain. Here are some of its finest:



The mother of all configuration tools

Customise IE’s Look

You’ll find these settings under User Configuration > Windows Settings > Internet Explorer Maintenance > Browser User Interface. Here you can add your own title to the IE title bar, change the icon on the top-right corner and even add your own custom toolbar buttons!



Changing the IE title text is just one of the settings you can customise

Clear The Page File On Shutdown

This setting may or may not improve your system’s performance (it depends on your usage patterns), but it does provide relief to the paranoid. Your Windows swap file may contain unencrypted text, including passwords, that could be exploited by interested parties. To delete the file when you shut down your system, you’ll find a setting under Computer Configuration > Windows Settings > Security Settings > Local Policies > Security Options called “Shutdown: Clear virtual memory pagefile”. Double-click this, select Enabled and click OK. Your shutdown time will increase marginally, though.

No More Windows CD

To avoid the hassle of hunting down your Windows XP CD every time you want to restore a system file (Windows File Protection at work) or add and remove components, just copy the entire thing to your disk and modify a setting in the Group Policy Editor. Navigate to Computer Configuration > Administrative Templates > System. On the right-hand pane, you’ll find “Specify Windows installation file location”. Double-click this, select Enable, and enter the path to your Windows XP setup file. You can even point it to a network path on your office LAN, so you don’t have to run to your system admin every time Windows wants the installation CD.

Disable Windows Key Shortcuts

If (for whatever reason) you want to prevent users from using shortcuts like [Windows] + [E] and so on, navigate to User Configuration > Administrative Templates > Windows Components > Windows Explorer and enable the “Turn off Windows + X hotkeys” setting.

No More System Tray

You’ll find this setting under User Configuration > Administrative Templates > Start Menu and Taskbar. Double-click “Hide the Notification Area”